

A story for founders

Founder Fog

A year in the founder's chair, and how to see through the fog



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Founder Fog

ضباب المؤسس

A story about Salma, Tariq and Hisham, and the first year of a company.

Written for people starting a company, and for anyone thinking about it.

Pictures: needle-felted art made for this book. Fonts: Manrope and Readex Pro (SIL Open Font Licence).

A sample chapter. The full book is in progress.

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Before you start

Every founder works in a fog. You cannot see the market clearly, the numbers arrive late, and when you are tired the fog gets thicker. This book follows Salma through the first year of a company that helps small shops get paid on time.

Each scene ends with a box called The fog lifts: one idea, in plain words, with where it comes from. At the end of each chapter there is a page of tools to use in your own company this week.

The story comes from Founder Fog, a free game where you run a startup week by week. Play a chapter, then play the year.

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The jump



Every company starts before it has a name: with a person, a problem that will not let go, and a sum on the back of an envelope.

The fog isn't out there in the market. Most of it is in your own head.

Hisham

In this chapter



Personal runway



Vesting



The Mom Test



Clarity

12 months

18,000

savings (\$)

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1,500

to live, a month

=

12

months



For six years Salma managed products at a bank in Cairo. Every month she watched small shops wait weeks to get paid, and borrow to cover the gap. Before she handed in her notice, she did one sum. Savings: \$18,000. Rent, food and bills: \$1,500 a month. That gave her 12 months, if nothing went wrong. Hisham, who had sold his first company, called it her personal runway. "Write it on the wall," he said. "Not to scare you. So you always know."



THE FOG LIFTS · PERSONAL RUNWAY

Savings divided by what you need to live each month. It is the clock that starts the day you quit, and founders who know it make calmer decisions.



CHAPTER 1 · 2

Half and half on a napkin

Tariq had built two apps nobody used, and he wanted this one to be different. In a café near Tahrir they drew a line down a paper napkin. Half for Salma, half for Tariq. "Deal?" said Tariq. Hisham put down his coffee. "Imagine it is month 8, and one of you wants to leave. Who keeps the half?" Nobody spoke. That night they agreed on vesting: shares earned over 4 years, and nothing until the end of year one. It felt unromantic. It was the kindest thing they did all year.

THE FOG LIFTS · VESTING



Founder shares are earned over time, usually 4 years with a 1-year cliff. It protects whoever stays, and investors will ask for it anyway.

Noam Wasserman, *The Founder's Dilemmas* (2012)



CHAPTER 1 · 3

Don't build yet

Tariq wanted to start coding on Monday. Hisham asked for 20 conversations first, with one rule: never ask if they like the idea. So Salma sat on a stool in Umm Hany's grocery shop and asked about last month instead. How many customers paid later? How long did she wait? What did she do while she waited? Umm Hany pulled out a shoebox of paper receipts. "40 days, sometimes," she said. "I borrow from my brother." Nobody said the word app. Salma filled 6 pages.



THE FOG LIFTS · THE MOM TEST

Ask about what people did, not about your idea. Opinions are polite. What they did last month is data.

Rob Fitzpatrick, *The Mom Test* (2013)



CHAPTER 1 · 4

The first fog

3 weeks in, Salma was sleeping 5 hours a night. Her notes stopped making sense. She read the same email 4 times and answered the wrong question. Hisham called at midnight and heard it in her voice. "In my first company I thought being tired proved I cared," he said. "It was just the fog. It hides the numbers first, then the people." She closed the laptop. The next day she slept 8 hours, walked by the Nile, and found the mistake in her spreadsheet in 10 minutes.

THE FOG LIFTS · CLARITY



The founder is the company's first resource. Sleep, exercise and one evening off a week are how good decisions keep coming.

Michael Freeman and colleagues, research on founders' mental health (2015)

Tools for week 0

1. Personal runway

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savings to live, a month months

2. The co-founder talk: five questions for this month

- ☐ Who decides what, and who breaks a tie?

- ☐ How is the equity split, and does it vest?

- ☐ What happens if one of us leaves?

- ☐ How much does each of us need to live on?

- ☐ How do we disagree without breaking up?

3. Twenty conversations, before any code

One circle per conversation about what someone did last month.

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Salma has 12 months of savings, a co-founder, a mentor and a problem worth solving. What she does not have is a clear view. A story about the first year of a company, the fog every founder works in, and the ideas that help it lift.



Play the game free

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English and Arabic · No account

